“If I had done something different, they would still be alive.”

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Where it often comes from

After a death, the mind searches for what could have been done: a symptom missed, a call not made, a different route, a different decision. This is a normal part of grief, because the alternative, that we could not control it, is frightening. But it can turn into heavy self-blame.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, “My times are in Your hands.” Scripture teaches that God alone numbers our days. “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His saints.” David, after his child died, said, “Can I bring him back again? I will go to him, but he will not return to me.” The psalmist says, “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion.” We act on what we know at the time. Hindsight gives clarity that was not available then, and love does not make us all-knowing or all-powerful.

> *“My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me”* (Psalm 31:15).

Also see

> “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His saints” (Psalm 116:15).

> “Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion” (Lamentations 3:32).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- I should have noticed.
- If only I had called sooner.
- It is my fault.
- I let them die.
- I could have prevented it.
- I will never forgive myself.

Common logical errors

- Hindsight bias: Judging past choices by what I know now.
- Personalization: Taking responsibility for something beyond my control.
- Magical thinking: Believing that the right action would have guaranteed a different outcome.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should have known.

Challenging questions

- What did I know at the time, and what did I only learn afterward?
- Could I realistically have prevented this?

- What would I say to a friend who felt this way?
- What did I do out of love?
- What does it mean that God holds our times?
- Is there something real I need to confess, and if so, what does God say about forgiveness?

Truth summary

> I acted with the knowledge and strength I had at the time. Hindsight shows me things I could not see then. My times, and theirs, are in God's hands. I can grieve without condemning myself, and I can receive God's compassion.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Guilt/Shame
- Death/Dying
- God, All Knowing
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "If I had done something different, they would still be alive"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I had done something different, they would still be alive." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I know then?
- ☐ Could I have prevented it?
- ☐ What did I do out of love?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What do I need to confess?
- ☐ Who can I talk to?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My times are in God's hands.
- ☐ I acted on what I knew.
- ☐ Hindsight was not available then.
- ☐ God shows compassion.
- ☐ Love does not give control over life and death.
- ☐ I can be gentle with myself.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 31:15
  "My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:32
  "Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ What I did with love: Each day, write one thing you did out of love for them.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 31:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My times are in Your hands, and so are theirs.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write what you knew then. List the information and options you actually had.
- ☐ Write a letter. Tell your loved one what you wish you could say.
- ☐ Talk to someone. Share the guilt with a pastor, counselor, or friend.
- ☐ Practice self-compassion. Say, "I did the best I could with what I knew."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I had done something different, they would still be alive": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love remembered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I had done something different, they would still be alive.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I keep asking what I could have done. You know my heart and You hold our days. Release me from self-blame, and help me trust that my times and theirs are in Your hands. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.